

PIECING

Piecing, or sewing pieces of fabric (units or patches) together, lies at the heart of patchwork. In fact, piecing is, simply, creating patchwork. First you join smaller pieces, then you join these to make your

final design. You can choose between hand and machine piecing. Piecing by machine obviously produces faster results.

▶ HAND PIECING

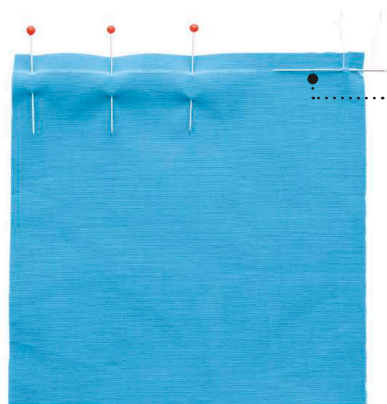
Mark all seamlines on the wrong side of the fabric to give you an accurate guide to where to sew. Take care when sewing seams on bias-cut edges (for instance on diamond, triangle, or hexagon shapes) or around curves, as the raw edge is prone to stretching. Secure the seam

with a small backstitch each time you bring the needle through and use a double backstitched loop (see p.40) at the end of a bias seam; do not sew into the seam allowance.

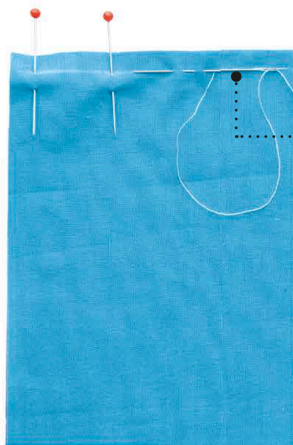
JOINING TWO UNITS WITH A STRAIGHT SEAM



1 Place the two units to be joined right sides together. You must not sew across the seam allowance of the adjacent seam, so mark that seam allowance with pins at the start and end points of the seam you are about to sew. Add more pins along the seamline you are about to sew, making sure that the seamline aligns on both units.



2 Remove the first pin and take the needle through both the front and the back units at that point. Secure the thread with a knot or take a couple of tiny backstitches into the seam allowance.



3 Take several short running stitches along the seamline, then pull the needle through. Repeat along the length of the seam, removing pins as you work.



4 From time to time, check the back of the fabric to make sure that your stitching is on the seamline on both sides. Stop at the end point marked with a pin in Step 1. Finish with a couple of backstitches to secure the thread.